



**FINAL JUSTICE:** Mahadik, Muneshwar, Palshikar, Mali (clockwise from left) awarded 10 years rigorous imprisonment and a fine of Rs 50,000, the longest sentence awarded to an accused in the blasts case.

Sayyed is accused of transporting AK-56 rifles, ammunition and hand grenades in a blue Maruti Esteem along with Abu Salem from actor and co-accused Sanjay Dutt's house and delivering them to co-accused Zebunnisa Kazi in Bandra. Sayyed, who has already spent nine years in prison, in his confession had claimed that he had agreed to the operation at the behest of Salem only to catch a glimpse of Dutt.

But while Ahmed has been convicted under the stringent TADA, Dutt has been let off under the Arms Act. Ahmed seemed resigned to his fate on hearing the sentence and remained quiet and aloof.

With these convictions, all eyes are on Dutt, whose court hearing comes up on May 25.

by Prerana Thakurdesai

## SIGNPOSTS

**ANNOUNCED:** Revenue Secretary **K. M. Chandrasekhar**, 59, as the new Cabinet Secretary. The 1970-batch IAS officer from Kerala cadre was India's ambassador to wto in Geneva before becoming the Revenue Secretary.

**ACQUITTED:** Congress MP **Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury**, in a case of murdering hotelier Hanif Sheikh and his son Laltu Sheikh two years ago, by a Baharampore court.



**RENAMED:** Lucknow's famous **King George Medical University**, set up during the British era, as **Chhatrapati Shahuji Maharaj Medical University**, after the Dalit icon, by the Mayawati Government.

**DIED:** Former Orissa minister **Murali Prasad Mishra**, 79. He was cooperatives minister in the state government headed by Rajendra Narayan Singh Deo from 1967-1971.

## The Sentencing Begins

**MUMBAI** The sentencing of four policemen accused of abetting the 1993 Mumbai blasts is the first conviction of public servants in the case. The Terrorist and Disruptive Activities Prevention Act (TADA) court on May 21 sentenced former constables Ashok Muneshwar, S.Y. Palshikar, R. Mali and P. Mahadik to six years rigorous imprisonment and imposed a fine of Rs 25,000 on each.

The constables were bribed Rs 59,000 each for

letting RDX pass through the Raigad coast in a truck. The court did not accept the CBI's plea for life imprisonment stating that the constables had acted under police sub-inspector V.K. Patil, who was the "main man". The court sentenced Patil to life imprisonment for criminal conspiracy and aiding and abetting a terrorist act and slapped a fine of Rs 2 lakh on him.

In another significant conviction, Mansoor Ahmed Sayyed was

**VIS-A-VIS** T.V. RAJESWAR Uttar Pradesh governor versus **AZAM KHAN** Samajwadi Party leader

**Anarchy prevailed in the past years. The people's verdict was ridiculed by forming an unconstitutional government.**



SAURABH SINGH

**How can the governor term a government unconstitutional when he himself had addressed similar joint sessions in the past regime?**

**EPILOGUE:** The governor's assertion comes a little late in the day.